🕊️ Genocide & Human Rights: Reading

World History · Unit 8 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Path to Nazi Genocide, Armenian Genocide and Apartheid/Rwanda sheets

Name: _____

From Prejudice to Genocide

In 1948 the United Nations defined genocide as acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial or religious group. Genocide rarely happens suddenly. It usually grows from prejudice and propaganda, to laws that take away rights, to violence that the government organizes.

After World War I and the Great Depression, many Germans were humiliated and desperate. Adolf Hitler, who wrote Mein Kampf ('My Struggle') in prison, blamed Germany's problems on Jewish people and other groups. The Nazis offered simple solutions by exploiting people's hopes and fears. Once in power in 1933, they declared emergency rule, suspended civil rights and opened concentration camps for political opponents. The 1935 Nuremberg Laws stripped Jews of citizenship and banned marriage between Jews and non-Jews. Nazi 'race science' was pseudoscience: false ideas dressed up as science. On November 9-10, 1938, Kristallnacht ('Night of Broken Glass'), Nazis attacked Jewish businesses, homes and synagogues. During World War II, the Nazis and their collaborators murdered about six million Jews, as well as Roma, disabled people and others. This is the Holocaust.

Earlier, during World War I, the Ottoman government, controlled by the Young Turks since 1908, targeted the Armenians, a Christian minority in a mostly Muslim empire. Beginning in 1915, Armenians were deported, marched into the desert and massacred. Estimates of the dead range from about 600,000 to 1.5 million. Turkey has long argued against calling these events genocide, but survivors' accounts and most historians describe them as one.

In South Africa, the white-minority government created apartheid ('apartness') in 1948. Laws separated people by race in housing, schools, beaches and benches, and forced Black South Africans into separate areas. Nelson Mandela led resistance, was imprisoned for 27 years, and in 1994 became the country's first Black president after apartheid ended.

In Rwanda in 1994, Hutu extremists, using radio propaganda, killed about 800,000 Tutsi and moderate Hutu in about 100 days. Studying these events shows how ordinary people can become perpetrators, bystanders, or upstanders who resist injustice.

Check your reading

1. List the steps that usually lead to genocide.

2. How did the Nazi Party gain public support?

3. Using the UN definition, explain why the events of 1915 are called the Armenian Genocide.